

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz AlMutairi

April 27, 2026

Definition

Let T be a linear operator, $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$ is called an eigenvalue of T , if there exists $x \in H$ with $x \neq 0$ such that

$$Tx = \lambda x$$

Definition

Let T be a linear operator. The resolvent set of T , denoted by $\rho(T)$, is $\rho(T) = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : T - \lambda I \text{ is invertible}\}$. The spectrum of T , denoted by $\sigma(T)$ is $\sigma(T) = \mathbb{C} \setminus \rho(T)$, or equivalently, $\sigma(T) = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : T - \lambda I \text{ is not invertible}\}$

Theorem

Let H be a Hilbert space and $T : H \rightarrow H$ then T is invertible $\iff \ker T^ = \{0\}$ and $\exists \alpha > 0$ such that $\|T(x)\| \geq \alpha \|x\| \quad \forall x \in H$.*

Corollary

Let H be a Hilbert space and $T : H \rightarrow H$ then T is invertible $\iff \exists \beta > 0$ such that $\|T^(x)\| \geq \beta \|x\|$ and $\exists \alpha > 0$ such that $\|T(x)\| \geq \alpha \|x\| \quad \forall x \in H$.*

Proof.

If T is invertible, then so is T^* . So, by Theorem 1, $\exists \beta > 0$ such that $\|T^*(x)\| \geq \beta \|x\|$ and $\exists \alpha > 0$ such that $\|T(x)\| \geq \alpha \|x\|$ for all $x \in H$. Conversely, if $\exists \beta > 0$ such that $\|T^*(x)\| \geq \beta \|x\|$, then if $T^*u = 0$ for some $u \in H$, then

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &= \|T^*u\| \geq \beta \|u\| \\ &\implies u = 0 \end{aligned}$$

So, $\ker T^* = \{0\}$. By Theorem 1, T is invertible. □

Remark

Notice that, if $T \in B(H)$, by Theorem 1, we can rewrite the resolvent set of T as

$$\rho(T) = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : \ker(T - \lambda I)^* = \{0\} \text{ and } \|(T - \lambda I)x\| \geq \alpha\|x\| \\ \text{for some } \alpha > 0\}$$

Alternatively, we can rewrite the resolvent set of T as

$$\rho(T) = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : \|(T - \lambda I)^*x\| \geq \beta\|x\| \text{ and } \|(T - \lambda I)x\| \geq \alpha\|x\| \\ \text{for some } \beta, \alpha > 0\}$$

by Corollary 1

Theorem

If λ is an eigenvalue of T , then $\lambda \in \sigma(T)$

Proof.

Suppose that $\lambda \notin \sigma(T)$, then $T - \lambda I$ is invertible. So, we have $(T - \lambda I)u = 0 \implies u = (T - \lambda I)^{-1}(T - \lambda I)u = (T - \lambda I)^{-1}(0) = 0$. So, if there is $u \in \mathcal{H}$ such that $Tu = \lambda u$, then $u = 0$. So, λ is not an eigenvalue of T . □

Theorem

Let H be a finite dimensional Hilbert space, and let $T : H \rightarrow H$ be linear. If $\lambda \in \sigma(T)$, then λ is an eigenvalue of T .

Remark

For finite dimensional Hilbert space, the spectrum of T consist only the eigenvalues of T . However, in infinite dimensional Hilbert space, we may have no eigenvalues. For instance, consider the shift operator. Here, it has no eigenvalues, since if we consider $(T - \lambda I)x = 0$, we see that

$$(-\lambda x_1, x_1 - \lambda x_2, x_2 - \lambda x_3, \dots) = (0, 0, 0, \dots) \implies x = (0, 0, 0, \dots)$$

So, T does not have an eigenvalue. However, we showed that T is not invertible. So, $T - 0I$ is not invertible and $0 \in \sigma(T)$. So, the spectrum of an operator does not only consist of eigenvalues.

Proof.

Suppose that λ is not an eigenvalue of T , then there is nonzero $u \in H$ such that $Tu = \lambda u$. So, there is no nonzero $u \in H$ such that $(T - \lambda I)u = 0$. So, $\ker(T - \lambda I) = \{0\}$. By rank-nullity theorem, we have

$$\begin{aligned}\dim H &= \dim \ker(T - \lambda I) + \dim \operatorname{Im}(T - \lambda I) \\ &= 0 + \dim \operatorname{Im}(T - \lambda I) \\ &= \dim \operatorname{Im}(T - \lambda I)\end{aligned}$$

So, $\operatorname{Im}(T - \lambda I) = H$. This means that $(T - \lambda I)$ is surjective, and therefore, invertible. So, $\lambda \in \rho(T)$, and therefore, $\lambda \notin \sigma(T)$. $\square$

Proposition

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a Hilbert space. Let $T : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ be linear operator. The following properties hold:

1. $\sigma(I) = \{1\}$
2. $\sigma(T^*) = \{\bar{\lambda} : \lambda \in \sigma(T)\}$
3. If T is invertible, then $\sigma(T^{-1}) = \{\mu^{-1} : \mu \in \sigma(T)\}$
4. If T is self-adjoint, then $\sigma(T) \subseteq \mathbb{R}$.
5. If $U : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ is invertible, then $\sigma(UTU^{-1}) = \sigma(T)$

Theorem

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a complex Hilbert space and let $T \in B(\mathcal{H})$. If $|\lambda| > \|T\|$ then $\lambda \notin \sigma(T)$.

Corollary

If $T \in B(H)$, then $\sigma(T)$ is bounded.

Proof.

If $\lambda \in \sigma(T)$, then, by the contrapositive of Theorem 4, $|\lambda| \leq \|T\|$.
So, $\lambda \in \overline{B(0, \|T\|)}$. Hence, $\sigma(T) \subseteq \overline{B(0, \|T\|)}$, i.e. $\sigma(T)$ is bounded. □

Theorem

If $T \in B(H)$, then $\sigma(T) \subseteq \mathbb{C}$ is a closed set.

Corollary

If $T \in B(H)$, then $\sigma(T)$ is compact in $\mathbb{C}$

Lemma

If $\mathcal{H}$ is a complex Hilbert space and $U \in B(\mathcal{H})$ is unitary then

$$\sigma(U) \subseteq \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| = 1\}$$

An Example